
2. Conceptualizing affective polarization

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INTRODUCTION

Affective polarization has become a major subfield of research in political science. As with any innovative concept, there is ongoing debate over the precise definition of affective polarization and the phenomena it encompasses. In this respect, affective polarization is no different from its close cousin, ideological polarization, whose definition and conceptualization have created significant debate across the discipline (Dalton, 2008; Lelkes, 2016; see also Chapter 13).

In this chapter, we discuss the definition and conceptualization of affective polarization. We begin with relevant debates in the United States (US), the country in which this research agenda originated and on which it has mostly focused. We then turn to a detailed discussion of how the conceptualization of affective polarization has been adapted to the study of multiparty systems. While we necessarily touch on implications for measurement, these are discussed in more detail in Chapters 4 and 5 in this *Handbook*. We then clarify how affective polarization differs conceptually from related concepts, specifically negative partisanship, partisan prejudice and discrimination, ideological polarization, and democratic norms. Finally, we turn to current discussions over the conceptualization of affective polarization: what are the two endpoints of the concept, and how can affective polarization be applied to non-partisan political identities? We conclude by summarizing key open debates concerning the conceptualization of affective polarization.

CONCEPTUAL ORIGINS IN THE UNITED STATES

While the concept of affective polarization can be applied to any set of social identities and social groups, the origins of this research agenda lie squarely in *partisan* affective polarization, defined as ‘the extent which partisans view each other as a disliked out-group’ (Iyengar et al., 2012). In the context of the US party system, affective polarization captures the social identities of and mutual affect between Democrats and Republicans. For the US, a succinct definition of partisan affective polarization is thus ‘the tendency of people identifying as Republicans or Democrats to view opposing partisans negatively and copartisans positively’ (Iyengar & Westwood, 2015).

The general definition of affective polarization has two components: positive in-group affect and negative out-group affect. In general terms, affective polarization is therefore based on both in-group favoritism and out-group animus. Applied to parties, it increases when individuals feel more positively about their in-party and more negatively about their out-party. Note that affective polarization may relate to important emotional reactions such as pride,

hope, fear, and anger (see Chapter 13 in this *Handbook*), but the foundation of the concept is positive and negative affect rather than distinct emotions.

Research on affective polarization builds on long-standing research on social identities (Greene, 1999; 2004, Green et al., 2004; Huddy et al., 2015; West & Iyengar, 2022). In social psychology, the pioneering work in this tradition was conducted in the post-war decades, including the famous ‘Robber’s Cave’ experiment (Sherif et al., 1961) as well as research on the minimal group paradigm (Tajfel, 1970). This research established that humans tend to divide themselves into social groups (Brewer, 1991), and that the basis of such divisions can be trivial (Billig & Tajfel, 1973).

Positive in-group affect can therefore result from an in-group social identity, also known as (positive) partisanship. Research in the US has tended to confirm that partisanship goes beyond mere support and acts as an important social identity (see Chapter 10). This means that partisan support is more than an attitude based on ideological proximity (Greene, 1999, 2004). In the US, the political behavior that results from partisan identities is better explained by expressive rather than instrumental motivations: rather than representing a running tally of ideological and valence-based support, partisanship reflects a ‘psychological attachment’ to a party (Huddy et al., 2015). At the same time, Elliott (2023) argues that ‘conceptualizing party attachment is among the most contested ground in political science,’ pointing out, for example, that it is not clear that all those who feel close to a party also identify with it. Positive partisanship is thus an established, if still debated, concept, and it is related to and conducive to affective polarization, but not essential to it.

Arguably, the real innovation in the affective polarization research program was the focus on negative out-group affect. Out-group animus may be a natural outgrowth of positive partisan identities: for partisans, the world is divided into an in-party and an out-party (Tajfel & Turner, 1979; Iyengar et al., 2019). An important question, accordingly, is the relative contribution of in-group and out-group affect toward group evaluations. Some have even questioned the need for in-party identification and positive affect as a precursor to negative out-party affect (Abramowitz and Webster, 2016; Iyengar et al., 2012). Some research, especially in multiparty systems, even focuses solely on out-party affect, moving away from the initial focus on the gap between in-party like and out-party dislike (Gidron et al., 2023; Röllicke, 2023).

The key foundational empirical finding of initial research on affective polarization was that out-party affect had become increasingly negative over the past decades, while positive in-party affect had remained largely stable (Iyengar et al., 2012; Finkel et al., 2020). This finding could be established because the American National Election Study asked respondents to rate Republicans and Democrats on a 0–100 feeling thermometer from 1964 onwards.

The importance of negative group affect was soon confirmed by examining similar phenomena, such as social distancing from political opponents and perceived group traits. Thus, out-partisans in the US are assigned more negative traits (such as selfishness) and fewer positive traits (such as intelligence) (Iyengar et al., 2012; Garrett et al., 2014). In-partisans are also likely to state that they would be unhappy if their co-worker or the partner of a son/daughter was an out-partisan (Iyengar et al., 2012; Levendusky & Malhotra, 2016). Implicit association tests further show that partisan affect is deeply ingrained in the US and stronger than racial bias (Iyengar & Westwood, 2015).

THE CONCEPT OF AFFECTIVE POLARIZATION IN MULTIPARTY SYSTEMS

Outside the US, researchers have only relatively recently begun to study affective polarization. The first articles that studied inter-partisan animosity in multiparty systems appeared in the late 2010s (Westwood et al., 2018; Martini & Torcal, 2019; Helbling & Jungkunz, 2020), and papers that used cross-national data and like-dislike scores toward parties soon followed (Ward & Tavits, 2019; Reiljan, 2020; Wagner, 2021; Gidron et al., 2023). Since then, there has been a marked increase in work on affective polarization outside the US (Wagner, 2024). This has also dealt with important conceptual questions concerning the poles and objects of affective polarization outside the US context (see below for a detailed discussion of this). However, the slowness with which this concept was adapted elsewhere is not solely due to such conceptual issues and begs the question of why it took so long for comparative scholars to embrace this concept.

A first response could be that affective polarization had actually been covered in past research but was felt to have little to tell us about today's politics in many multiparty systems. Almond and Verba (1963) and Powell (1970) focused on inter-partisan hostility in Europe, specifically the UK, Germany, Austria, and Italy, but their focus was already more on the decrease in such enmity since the interwar period. Partisanship—a key component of affective polarization—had long been seen as in decline in Europe (Heath, 2017), with one key text even entitled 'Parties without Partisans?' (Dalton & Wattenberg, 2002). This title is telling, even if the question mark indicates that this was not seen as an entirely settled issue.

The work on social cleavages by Lipset and Rokkan (1967) is also based on group identities and intergroup affect, solidified over time into enduring identities and attachments. But here too, the literature tends to concentrate on the past and the origins of party systems, with the recent literature mainly focusing on dealignment (Franklin et al., 1992), depolarization (Adams et al., 2012) and fragmentation (Best, 2013), rather than on polarization and inter-partisan hostility.

However, recent empirical work has shown that the US is by no means an outlier in terms of its level of affective polarization (Wagner, 2021), even if many countries have not witnessed the same kind of rise in affective polarization as has the US (Boxell et al., 2022; Torcal & Comellas, 2022; Garzia et al., 2023). It may be that two-party systems generate a stronger sense of politics as a zero-sum game, raising the stakes for partisans, while multiparty systems' more complex settings, with several 'in-' and 'out-' parties and coalition politics, make for multiple 'winners.' Empirical patterns of affective polarization indeed point to lower levels in proportional than in majoritarian systems (McCoy and Somer, 2019; Gidron et al., 2020), perhaps another element of the 'kinder, gentler' politics these systems lead to (Lijphart, 2010). Psychological research indeed suggests that out-party animus is more likely to be expressed in the former case (Brewer, 2001, 2016).

DISTINGUISHING AFFECTIVE POLARIZATION FROM RELATED CONCEPTS

While the term affective polarization dominates scholarly research on inter-partisan dislike, other related terms appear frequently in the literature. Mason (2015) uses the term 'social

polarization’ to refer to the same phenomenon, namely polarization driven by partisan identities. Moreover, affective polarization is strongly related to the concept of ‘political sectarianism’ (Finkel et al., 2020), defined as ‘the tendency to adopt a moralized identification with one political group and against another.’ Political sectarianism has three components: othering, i.e., the tendency to view out-partisans as separate and different; aversion, i.e., dislike towards out-partisans; and moralization, i.e., the tendency to view out-partisans as iniquitous. It is the third component, moralization, that most clearly sets political sectarianism apart from affective polarization.

Similarly, affective polarization is closely linked to the concept of ‘pernicious polarization’ (McCoy et al., 2018), which refers to the polarization that occurs when ‘differences become aligned within (normally two) camps with mutually exclusive identities and interests,’ creating an Us-versus-Them dynamic that pervades the political system. In other words, the pernicious polarization examined by McCoy et al. (2018) refers to a specific pattern of affective polarization in a context characterized by high levels of social sorting.

In addition, affective polarization needs to be kept distinct from other related phenomena: partisan prejudice and discrimination, negative partisanship, ideological polarization, and democratic norms.

Affective Polarization and Partisan Prejudice and Discrimination

First, affective polarization is distinct from the partisan prejudice and discrimination it leads to. Affective polarization refers to the combination of positive partisan identities and negative out-party affect, while partisan bias and discrimination are consequences of identity and affect (Mason, 2015). These consequences are extensive, as research has shown that affective polarization powerfully influences individuals’ downstream attitudes and behavior. Thus, there is evidence of partisan bias in the evaluation of job applicants (Gift & Gift, 2015), assessments of physical attractiveness (Nicholson et al., 2016), selection of potential romantic partners (Huber & Malhotra, 2017) and the awarding of academic scholarships (Iyengar & Westwood, 2015).

Measures of social distance similarly capture the (intended) behavioral consequences of affective polarization. In economic games, individuals are clearly willing to discriminate against others based on their partisan sympathies (Carlin & Love, 2013; Iyengar & Westwood, 2015; Halevy et al., 2012). In addition, real-world economic decisions are colored by partisan bias (McConnell et al., 2018). Finally, affective polarization might lead to intolerance towards political outgroups, although this relationship is not straightforward (see next section and Chapter 25). In sum, it is important to separate affective polarization from its consequences for attitudes and behavior.

Affective Polarization and Negative Partisanship

Negative partisanship is related to but distinct from affective polarization (see Chapter 12 in this *Handbook*). Some researchers equate negative partisanship with negative out-party affect (Abramowitz & Webster, 2018). However, others see negative partisanship as a social identity that is similar to positive partisanship but is also a distinct construct (Rose & Mishler, 1998; Medeiros & Noël, 2014; Mayer, 2017; Samuels & Zucco, 2018; Bankert, 2021). The argument is that the social identity framework can also be used to account for negative partisan

identities, which “center on the rejection of the out-group’s characteristics” (Bankert, 2021). Survey questions to measure negative partisanship as a distinct identity more explicitly have been developed (Samuels & Zucco, 2018; Bankert, 2021; Areal, 2022). Overall, negative partisanship as a term implies negative partisan identification; out-party dislike and negative party affect are useful alternative terms for those who do not want to imply the existence of negative identification. As with positive partisanship, affective polarization does not require the existence of a negative partisan identity, but such identities are consistent with the theoretical foundations of affective polarization.

A related, essential distinction is between those who are affectively polarized and those who dislike all partisans. Many people prefer to avoid individuals who are very politically engaged (Klar et al., 2018). Social distance measures can also capture such dislike (Druckman and Levendusky, 2019; Krupnikov & Ryan, 2022). Moreover, when survey respondents are asked to think about typical partisans, they tend to overestimate such individuals’ ideological extremity and political engagement (Druckman and Levendusky, 2019). These studies serve as an important reminder that it is important to have a clear understanding of who the out-partisans are that people feel negative affect towards.

Affective Polarization and Ideological Polarization

Before the research agenda on affective polarization gained pace, the dominant way of thinking about polarization was ideological, with the focus on the policy differences between the major parties (see Chapter 14 in this *Handbook*). Ideological and affective polarization are conceptually entirely distinct: while the first is based on the policy preferences of partisans, the latter is based on affect and identities. At the same time, ideological and affective polarization are not independent phenomena. Iyengar et al. (2012, p. 406) already recognized that ‘affect based on partisan identity may reflect some combination of ideological disagreements and group-centric “impulses.”’ Indeed, increased ideological polarization is associated with increased positive partisanship and affective polarization (Abramowitz & Saunders, 2006; Rogowski & Sutherland, 2016; Webster & Abramowitz, 2017).

A key recent debate concerns whether it even makes sense to think of party affect without reference to policies and ideologies (Orr & Huber, 2020; Dias & Lelkes, 2021; Orr et al., 2023). At the same time, it is important to be clear that party affect is closely tied to perceived ideological distance; people can hold high levels of negative party affect without being ideologically extreme (Iyengar et al., 2012; Mason, 2015), and increases in affective polarization can occur even when ideological polarization declines (Levendusky & Malhotra, 2016).

Affective Polarization and Democratic Norms

Finally, affective polarization also has systemic consequences, including for democracy itself. Some researchers find that higher levels of affective polarization lead voters to be more likely to accept an erosion of democratic norms (see Chapter 26 in this *Handbook*), as long as it is the in-party that accepts norm violations (Graham & Svobik, 2020; Kingzette et al., 2021). However, recent findings question the impact of affective polarization on democratic norms (Broockman et al., 2022; Voelkel et al., 2023). In comparative analyses, affective polarization correlates with democratic backsliding (Somer and McCoy, 2018; Orhan, 2022; see Chapter 27). Yet, affective polarization can also have positive consequences for democracy

by clarifying choices and promoting electoral mobilization (McCoy et al., 2018; Ahn & Mutz, 2023; Hartevelde & Wagner, 2023).

Affective polarization can also lead to more fraught, conflict-ridden intergroup relations. Negative partisan affect is linked to dehumanization (Cassese, 2020; Martherus et al., 2021). The use of political violence may be seen as more acceptable when affective polarization is high (Finkel et al., 2020; Kalmoe & Mason, 2022; though see Westwood et al., 2022). Yet, while there is an intimate relationship between affective polarization and its consequences for democracy (McCoy et al., 2018), the two are conceptually distinct.

THE POLES OF AFFECTIVE POLARIZATION

Affective polarization implies the existence of two poles. In two-party systems such as the US, it is clear what these two poles are, but this is more difficult to conceptualize once one moves to multiparty settings. In general, each of the two poles poses conceptual challenges. First, what counts as the in-party in multiparty systems is a potential matter for debate. Second, in multiparty systems, there may be multiple out-parties. We will tackle each question in turn.

What is the In-party?

First, citizens in multiparty systems can potentially have more than just one favored party. A strong conceptualization of positive partisanship would imply that partisan social identities are exclusive: since parties are always in competition with one another, it would not make sense to identify with more than one party (Garry, 2007). However, the reality of party competition in multiparty systems suggests otherwise, and empirically, we observe that individuals feel warmly toward and even close to more than one party and its supporters.

What creates positive feelings toward more than one party? One possibility is that several parties may be on the same side of key ideological divides, for instance, left and right, and that these proximate ideologies actually create the most important social identities (Oshri et al., 2022; Kekkonen & Ylä-Anttila, 2021). It may also be that the close cooperation that is often present in multiparty systems – e.g., in coalitions – might lead individuals to transfer affect towards partners of the party one identifies with (Horne et al., 2023; Bantel, 2023). They might even develop identities associated with the governing coalition rather than its component parties.

Moreover, in some countries, many citizens do not feel particularly close to any party at all. The trend in positive partisanship is clearly downward in many contexts (Heath, 2017; Holmberg & Oscarsson, 2020); in countries such as Germany, the UK, Sweden, and Canada, only around 50 percent of survey respondents state that they feel close to a party, and in some places, this is far lower (31 percent in Ireland, 13 percent in Chile). However, existing tools for measuring partisan identities also do a good job of capturing this phenomenon in multiparty systems (Bankert et al., 2017; Bankert 2024), so the nature of partisanship outside the US context is clearly still a matter of extensive academic debate. Importantly, a positive partisan identity among citizens is not necessary for affective polarization to be useful as a concept (Wagner, 2021). Even if partisan social identities are weak, individuals still feel affect towards partisans and react positively or negatively to these.

What is the Out-party?

Second, an obvious feature of multiparty systems is that most partisans do not have one out-party but several. When thinking about out-party hostility, we need to consider not just how much individuals dislike the other party, but all other parties to which they do not feel close. This means that researchers must think about what they are interested in when examining patterns of partisan affect. Do they want to know how disliked and distrusted the least-liked party is? Or are they interested in how disliked and distrusted, on average, other parties and their supporters are? And is it important whether individuals, in fact, have an in-party they feel attached to?

One solution is to consider each out-party individually and examine negative party affect or out-partisan hostility, rather than the affective polarization of the system as a whole. This captures what most researchers are interested in: the extent to which citizens view supporters of a political party as a disliked outgroup (Röllicke, 2023). Such affective dislike can ultimately lead to negative partisanship (see Chapter 12 in this *Handbook*).

Research on multiparty systems in Europe has found that there is one particular type of party that is a particularly strong target of dislike: the radical right (Helbling & Jungkunz, 2020; Bjanesoy, 2023; Meléndez & Kaltwasser, 2023). This category includes parties such as the Alternative for Germany, the Brothers of Italy, or Vox in Spain, which advocate clear right-wing positions, especially on topics relating to migration and law and order. These parties are often outsiders in European party systems and frequently challenge democratic norms. Among those who oppose these parties, dislike is often high, perhaps also because social norms fail to discourage voicing such feelings – and in some cases maybe even encourage doing so.

The presence of small parties means that the electoral strength of parties becomes an important dimension of affective polarization. Strength can be assessed using parties' current electoral support, the number of loyal partisans, or their past electoral success. In conceptual terms, it becomes important to distinguish between party systems in which many citizens strongly dislike partisans of a minor party and systems in which the animus is directed at a major party that could form the next government. It matters whether a disliked party has 5 or 35 percent support. Yet, a small but highly disliked competitor can still change political debates and interactions in society.

THE OBJECTS OF AFFECTIVE POLARIZATION

The concept of affective polarization in the US always concerns how individual partisans relate to one another. Thus, Iyengar and Westwood (2015) show that partisan loyalties create social divides and influence decisions outside politics. This is what, in work on multiparty systems, has been called horizontal affective polarization (Harteveld, 2021) or social affective polarization (Mason, 2015; Reiljan, 2021); note that Mason's definition of social polarization goes beyond affective polarization, as it also includes downstream consequences, specifically judgment (bias) and behavior (activism).

Horizontal affective polarization contrasts with dislike towards party elites and party leaders, which has been called vertical (Harteveld, 2021) or political (Reiljan, 2020) affective polarization. Others distinguish voter, party, and leader affective polarization: VAP, PAP, and

LAP, respectively (Torcal & Comellas, 2022; Reiljan et al., 2023). Voter-level or ‘horizontal’ affective polarization concerns feelings towards other citizens; party-level or ‘vertical’ affective polarization concerns feelings towards party elites; and leader affective polarization relates to affect towards political leaders (Harteveld, 2021; Reiljan et al., 2023). Leader and party affect can have downstream consequences on inter-partisan relations. For example, politicians can act as ‘prototypes’ of group members (Huddy, 2001). In some cases, affect and allegiance towards leaders can also create social groups and social identities: there are *Bolsonaristas* in Brazil, while ‘Trump voter’ is used as a social category in the US.

The most innovative contribution of the concept of affective polarization is its focus on partisans as groups in society. In contrast, party and leader affective polarization are much more familiar concepts, relating to summary judgments towards political elites. Thus, leader-level valence and traits have long been studied in political science (e.g., Funk, 1999, Aarts et al., 2013; Costa Lobo & Curtice, 2014), while party-level affect is closely related to models of party preference based on ideology, identity, and valence (e.g., Adams et al., 2020). While party or leader affective polarization are useful concepts, they also tie into different, more long-standing fields of research in political science. One practical reason these two concepts have taken on relevance is perhaps because the relevant measures have been included in so many surveys, for instance, the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems.

Finally, group-based affect can extend to other politically relevant groups, especially if these groups create the kinds of dichotomies that foster strong social identities and deep political divisions. One potential alternative is ideological identities (Ellis & Stimson, 2012; Oshri et al., 2022). Ideologies can be key reference points for voters, with citizens identifying as being liberal or left-wing rather than as supporters of a particular party. These can divide citizens, for example, left and right, and can do so in ways that mirror the Republican-Democrat divide in the US (Comellas & Torcal, 2023). Bantel (2023) argues that party affect in Europe mainly revolves around three ideological blocs: left, right, and radical right (see also Kekkonen and Ylä-Anttila, 2021 on Finland). Similarly, particular issues can create strong ‘us against them’ divides that may fulfill similar functions as partisan identities (see Chapter 14): think of Brexit (Hobolt et al., 2021), the debate surrounding Catalan independence (Balcells and Kuo, 2022) or the territorial conflict in Spain (Rodon, 2022), or conflicts based on support or opposition to measures to combat COVID-19 (Bor et al., 2023).

FUTURE DEBATES

This chapter has explored key definitional and conceptual debates in research on affective polarization in the US and comparatively. The definition of affective polarization is unusually clear for a political science concept: it captures the gap between an individual’s positive in-group affect and his or her dislike for the out-group. Applied to parties, it refers to the combination of positive in-party affect and negative out-party affect.

It is useful to end this chapter with a brief summary of what affective polarization as a concept does not imply. First, high levels of affective polarization do not imply that citizens hold non-rational beliefs. There is a close link between ideological and affective polarization, and one often begets the other, but they are generally complementary rather than alternative understandings of political conflict. Second, affective polarization is not the same as the intensity of political debates among citizens or the extent of out-partisan discrimination. Rather,

these are consequences of affective polarization. A public clash between partisan groups is a sign of affective polarization, but not affective polarization per se.

Overall, affective polarization is a versatile concept that has proven to be robust and relevant in many contexts and settings. The research over the past decade has established it as a core element of political behavior studies. There are nevertheless key aspects that still generate debate. How important are partisan identities for affective polarization? What is the relationship between vertical (leader, party) and horizontal (citizen) affective polarization? And when is partisan affective polarization the central politically relevant affective divide in societies, and when is it supplanted by other types of group-based polarization? These are key questions that deserve further attention.

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